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POL215: Canadian Government

Kindergarten or Coliseum? Question Period and Canadian Democracy Analyzed

Quantitatively and Qualitatively

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Question Period in the Canadian House of Commons has specific qualities that have caused it to be described as resembling “a Roman coliseum where gladiators spill blood and fight for the crowd's emotions” (Chong, 2008). For the past several decades, Question Period has been observed to be rowdy in nature (Whyte, 2019), unlike equivalent traditions in other parliamentary democracies. Question Period is deeply institutionalized in Canadian politics as being the main opportunity for opposition parties to verbally ask the government questions and the government is effectively forced to respond. This paper will only analyze the House of Commons, although the Senate and provincial legislatures also have their own Question Periods. Using both quantitative and qualitative methods, this paper will show that Question Period strengthens Canadian democracy through accountability and informing the general public, despite its flaws.

Before analyzing the dynamics of Question Period, it is important to understand the incentives of why MPs choose to deliver speeches in the House of Commons. Similar to a theatrical play, it is often that MPs from both the governing party and the opposition provide answers and ask questions, respectively, that are directly written by their party leaders rather than themselves. This is likely partially due to why Question Period tends to sound repetitive as well as MPs of the same party generally speaking in the same tone. However, MPs still have some individual autonomy in what they choose to say. This is important since under the Canadian electoral regime citizens directly vote for their MPs to represent their views, rather than only the candidate's party. Utility functions can aid in clearly modelling these two incentives of achieving individual and collective party goals for when they

choose to speak. One of these utility functions consists of the variables of speech that successfully lead to a desired change in policy, increase in vote share, and increase of chance in remaining in office. Each of those three variables is multiplied by the probability of the speech successfully achieving those goals, minus the costs of delivering the speech, and finally adding the selective benefits of speaking, which is the personal benefit that the MP experiences (Bäck & Debus, 2016). Another example of a similar utility function involves weighting done by multiplying the collective benefits by a value between zero and one that represents the degree of party unity, and the individual benefits are weighted by one minus that party's unity value (Whyte, 2019).

Empirical quantitative analysis proves to a significant extent that the opposition party's questions and government's answers are not entirely random as would be the case if they were purely performative. The relationship between how relevant answers are to questions can be measured through a cosine similarity score between negative one and positive one. The closer the score is to zero, the less similar the question and answer are. The cosine similarity score is approximately calculated by dividing the amount of identical words in the question and answer by the total amount of words in both combined, although with additional mathematical weighting and matrix algebra (Whyte, 2019). The more similar a government response is to an opposition question, then the more likely that the government is seriously engaging with the question rather than avoiding it, and therefore being accountable. While this form of accountability is direct, accountability can also come in the more indirect form of furthering "public confidence in parliamentary oversight" (Greenway, 2025). As displayed in the Appendix (*Figure 1*), this paper observed a non-linear

correlation between cosine similarity and the current government's poll support. The cosine score is highest at 32.8% support in the polls for the government, and declines from that peak when support increases or decreases beyond 32.8%. However, as depicted in *Figure 1*, the cosine similarity increases again, when support in the polls is below about 15% and above about 45%, although this increase is not as high as the peak and may simply be statistical noise as the 95% confidence interval is far wider at these extreme areas than at the peak (Whyte, 2019). Whyte also used theoretical frameworks to analyze why the cosine similarity decreases for government poll support above and below the peak of 32.8%, as well as why it peaks at that 32.8% point. For support below the peak, governments would not have an incentive to appear to be accountable to the public since they know that they will very likely lose the next election regardless of how strong their answers are. For above the peak, governments also lack a strong incentive to appear accountable to the public due to them knowing that they likely will win the next election regardless of putting in more effort to engage more with opposition questions (Whyte, 2019). Additionally, if the government has strong support, then they likely are already viewed as being accountable by the public. Finally, Whyte explains that cosine similarity likely peaks at 32.8% since the government and the opposition each have strong incentives to appear accountable to the public as they both have a significant chance of forming government after the next election. While there clearly is a statistically significant correlation between the government's aggregate poll support and how much they directly engage with questions from the opposition, the paper found "no significant relationship between government seat percentage and parliamentary accountability" (Whyte, 2019).

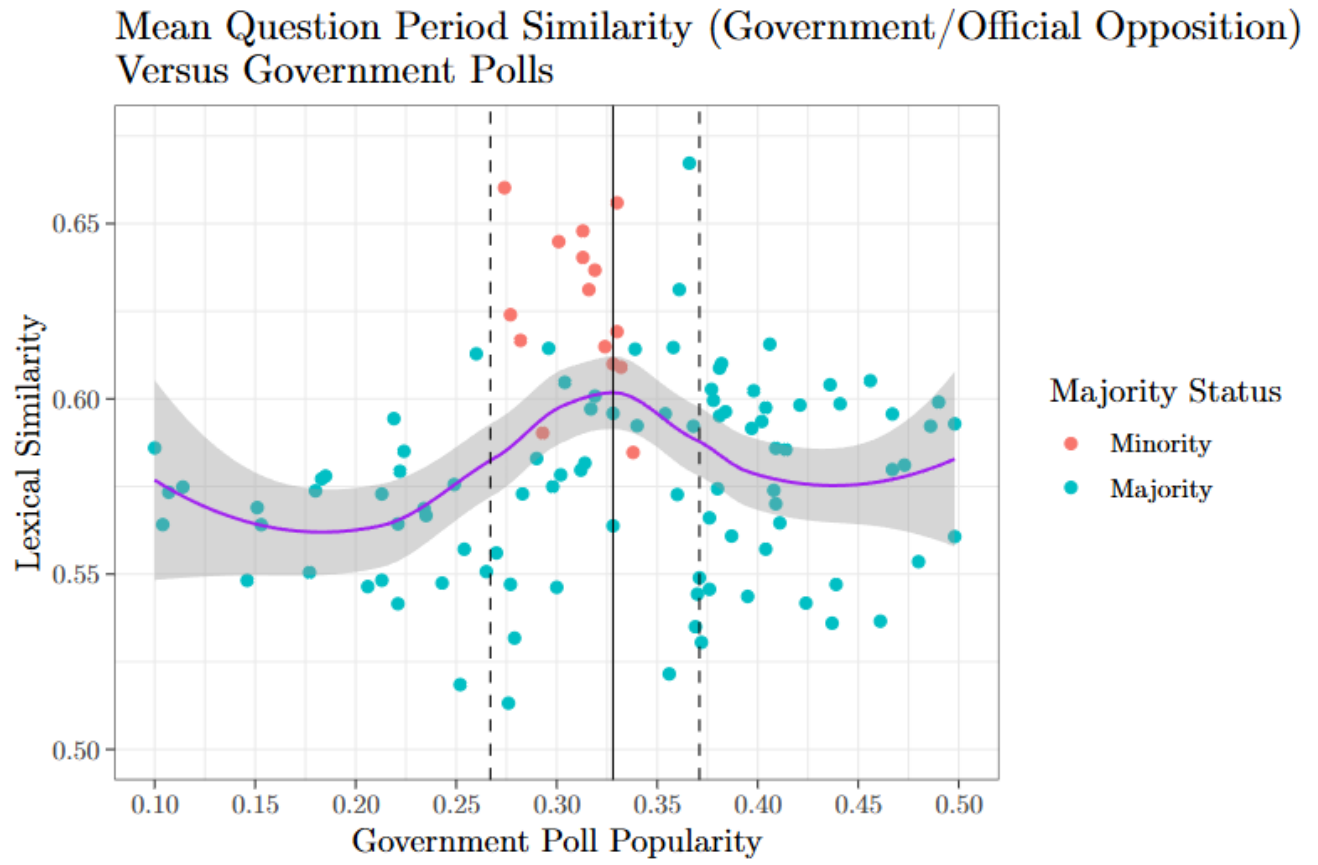
A separate paper was published in 2025 that also used cosine similarity to analyze how similar responses are to questions, and ultimately arrived at more nuanced conclusion about Question Period and parliamentary accountability. This is also significant that they arrived at a different conclusion since they used a more mathematically sophisticated Sentence-BERT neural network to calculate the cosine similarity which considers the meaning of the text rather than solely the words themselves. The paper uses this quantitative technique for 58,343 Question Period exchanges from between 2006 and 2021, which is a considerably shorter time interval than the Whyte paper whose data was from between 1945 and 2015. Similarity to the Whyte paper, they found that government replies are “generally at least moderately relevant, far exceeding what we would expect from random replies” (Alvarez & Morrier, 2025). Unlike the Whyte paper, this paper also analyzed and found a statistically significant correlation between “the quality of answers and the party affiliation of the members of Parliament asking the questions” and that “parties ideologically closer to the government tending to receive more relevant answers” (Alvarez & Morrier, 2025). This could reveal that ideological questioning can decrease accountability in Question Period, which is frequent due to the Official Opposition party holding different ideological beliefs than the government. An issue with Question Period related to this is that “rhetorical thirty five second questions produce rhetorical thirty five second answers” which is clearly not enough time to “advance the understanding of any particular issue” (Chong, 2008).

The extent that Question Period aids opposition parties, as well as the media and the general public, in holding the government to account is not unlimited. When a single

political party has a majority, passing legislation that they oppose has been described as being “akin to swimming up Niagara Falls” (Lepofsky, 2023). Additionally, it is important to note that in Question Period the role of opposition is “not simply to wound the government, but to prepare a government-in-waiting” (Marchi, 2026). Rather than having the government questioned by politically neutral individuals, such as judges, they are primarily held accountable by individuals who desire to replace their institutional position rather than solely aid them in governing better. Finally, Question Period has the tendency to overemphasize certain issues. For example, a 2023 paper on immigration debates found that refugees have been “constantly the most frequently discussed issue, despite being a relatively small part of the overall annual intake” (Pendakur et al., 2023). This disproportionality of the issues emphasized in debates could mislead the public on what the most pressing issues are in Canadian society.

In conclusion, Question Period is far more than political theatre or “Kindergarten on the Rideau” (Whyte, 2019), as it fundamentally enhances Canadian democracy through its primary purpose of holding the government to account, as well as informing the public about the current issues in civic discourse. Abolishing this traditional institution and replacing it with a simpler institution, such as solely written rather than oral questions and answers, would weaken democracy by decreasing how much the public takes time to pay attention to the decisions that their government makes. Other than accountability, this would also harm democracy in the sense that “the legitimacy of democratic decisions” derives “from the quality of discourse through which those decisions are made” (Greenaway, 2025). In my personal normative belief, society is better off if politics is not a

source of entertainment and instead is policy focused and technocratic. However, the entertainment value that Question Period provides likely strengthens democracy by keeping more Canadian citizens informed about the current party disagreements, and therefore keeps governments accountable to the consequences of the effects on society of their policy decisions.

Appendix*Figure 1:*

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